PUBLIC HEALTH WIDER DETERMINANTS ANALYSIS

Children in absolute low income and School Readiness

Across English Local Authorities, with a Focus on Cheshire West and Chester

Indicators analyzed

B01b - Children in absolute low-income families (under 16s)
B02a - School readiness: good level of development at end of Reception

Summary

Child poverty and early childhood development are closely linked wider determinants of health: the conditions in which children grow up shape their development and their future health and wellbeing. This report analyses two indicators from the OHID Public Health Outcomes Framework: children in absolute low-income families (B01b) and school readiness at the end of Reception (B02a), focusing on Cheshire West and Chester (CW&C) against England and against other English local authorities.

Key findings

- Trend (2021/22–2024/25): Child low income in CW&C rose from 15.6% to 17.8% before falling back to 15.1% by 2024/25, a net fall of 0.5 percentage points over the period. CW&C remained consistently below the England rate throughout, and the gap widened slightly to 4.7 points by 2024/25.
- Area comparison (2024/25): CW&C ranks 42nd lowest of 154 areas for child low income (15.1%, better than the England rate of 19.8%) but 22nd lowest of 153 areas for school readiness among free-school-meal (FSM) eligible children (45.0%, below the England rate of 51.3%).
- Relationship (2024/25): Across English local authorities, there is only a very weak, and not statistically significant, linear association between an area's overall child low-income rate and the school readiness of its FSM-eligible children (Pearson $r = 0.10$, $p = 0.22$, $n = 153$). A weak but statistically significant positive rank association is present (Spearman $\rho = 0.18$, $p = 0.03$). Still, area-level income deprivation explains at most a few per cent of the variation in FSM readiness outcomes.

Source: OHID Public Health Outcomes Framework, Fingertips
Prepared: September 2026

Background and Purpose

Child poverty and early childhood development are important wider determinants of health, as the conditions in which children grow can influence their development and future health and wellbeing. This report focuses on two indicators from the OHID Public Health Outcomes Framework: children in absolute low-income families under 16, and school readiness, measured by the percentage of children achieving a good level of development at the end of Reception.

The analysis examines changes in child low income in Cheshire West and Chester compared with England, compares local authority outcomes, and explores whether an observable association exists between child low income and school readiness across English local authorities. The analysis is exploratory and considers area-level patterns; it does not assume that one indicator causes changes in the other.

Analysis questions

1. How has the proportion of children in absolute low-income families changed in Cheshire West and Chester compared with England between 2021/22 and 2024/25?
2. How does Cheshire West and Chester compare with other English local authorities on child low income and school readiness in 2024/25?
3. Is there an observable association between child low income and the proportion of children with free school meal status achieving a good level of development at the end of Reception, across English local authorities in 2024/25?

Data and Methods

Indicators

Code	Indicator	Source
B01b	Children in absolute low-income families (under 16s)	OHID PHOF
B02a	School readiness: % of children achieving a good level of development at the end of Reception (free school meal-eligible children)	OHID PHOF

Geography

- Primary focus area: Cheshire West and Chester.
- National benchmark: England.
- Comparator set: all English upper-tier / unitary local authorities reporting both indicators (n = 153–154, depending on indicator and year).

Method notes

Question 1: compares annual published values for CW&C and England from 2021/22 to 2024/25 and derives year-on-year change and the gap to England.

Question 2: ranks all reporting local authorities on each indicator in 2024/25 and locates CW&C's position, alongside summary statistics (median, mean).

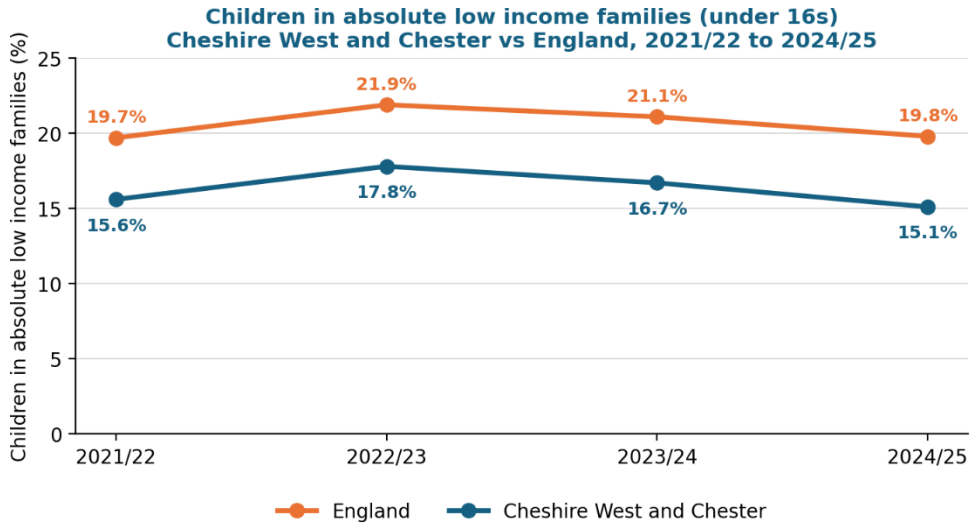
Question 3: tests the area-level relationship between B01b (child low income, all children) and B02a (school readiness, FSM-eligible children) in 2024/25 using Pearson's r (linear association) and Spearman's ρ (rank/monotonic association), since a small number of outlying areas with very small underlying pupil cohorts distort a purely linear reading.

Note:

All analyses are descriptive and observational. No adjustment was made for deprivation, ethnicity, school-level factors, or other confounders, and no causal inference is drawn.

Question 1

Trend: Cheshire West and Chester vs England (2021/22–2024/25)

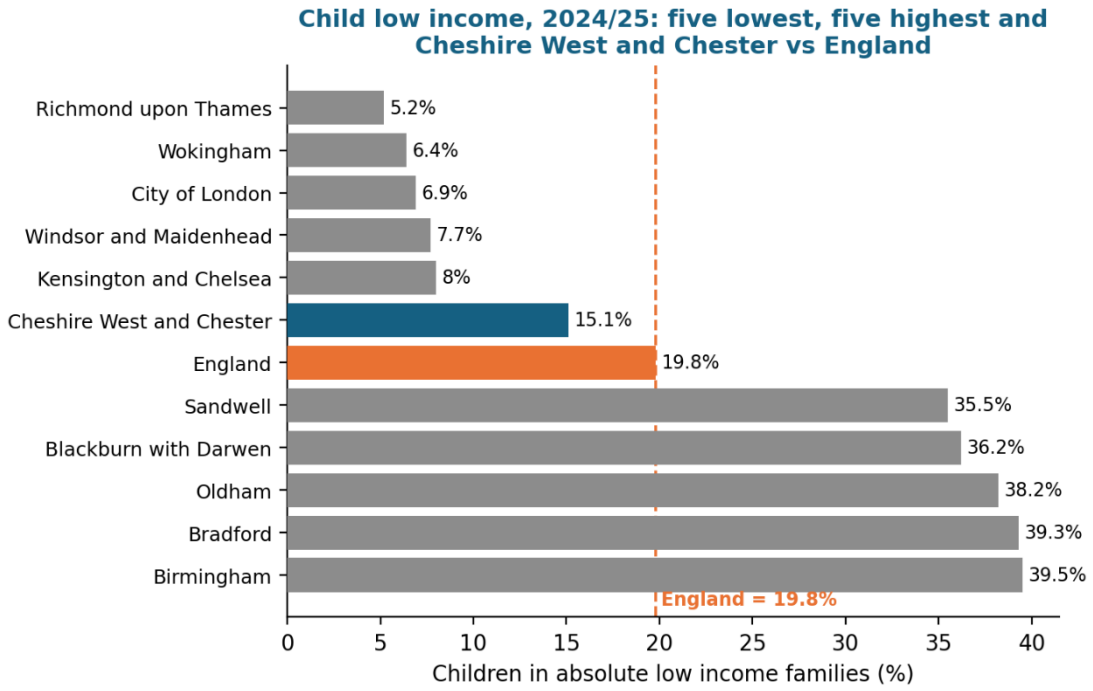


Year	CW&C (%)	England (%)	CW&C year-on-year (pp)	Gap vs England (pp)
2021/22	15.6	19.7	---	-4.1
2022/23	17.8	21.9	+2.2	-4.1
2023/24	16.7	21.1	-1.1	-4.4
2024/25	**15.1**	**19.8**	**-1.6**	**-4.7**

Key finding

Child low-income rates in Cheshire West and Chester increased between 2021/22 and 2022/23 (from 15.6% to 17.8%) before declining over the following two years to 15.1% in 2024/25, a net fall of 0.5 percentage points across the full period. CW&C's rate has remained below the England rate throughout, and the gap has widened modestly, from -4.1 percentage points in 2021/22 to -4.7 percentage points in 2024/25, meaning CW&C's improvement in the latest year slightly outpaced the small national fall (19.8% England vs 21.1% the year before).

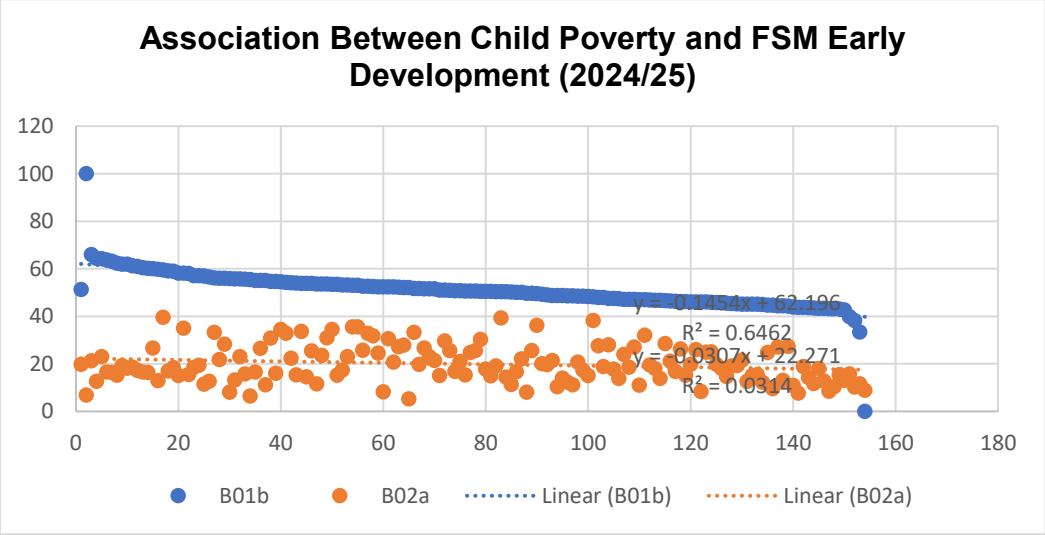
Question 2
Area Comparison, 2024/25



Metric	Value
Number of areas compared	154
England median	18.5%
England mean	19.9%
CW&C value	15.1%
CW&C rank (1 = lowest / best)	42nd of 154
Lowest area	Richmond upon Thames (5.2%)
Highest area	Birmingham (39.5%)

School readiness, FSM-eligible children (B02a)

Metric	Value
Number of areas compared	154
England median	18.5%
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CW&C value	15.1%
CW&C rank (1 = lowest / best)	42nd of 154
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Highest area	Birmingham (39.5%)



Statistic	Value	Interpretation
Areas included	n = 153	England excluded (national aggregate)
Pearson's r	0.10	Very weak positive linear association
p-value (Pearson)	0.22	Not statistically significant at the 5% level
Spearman's ρ	0.18	Weak positive rank association
p-value (Spearman)	0.03	Statistically significant at the 5% level

Key finding

There is no meaningful linear association between an area's overall child low-income rate and the school readiness of its FSM-eligible children in 2024/25: Pearson's r is close to zero (0.10) and not statistically significant. A weak but statistically significant positive rank correlation (Spearman's ρ = 0.18) suggests some tendency for FSM readiness to be marginally higher, not lower, in higher-poverty areas the opposite direction to what is often assumed but the relationship is weak enough that area-level low-income rates explain only a small fraction of the variation in FSM school readiness outcomes across England.

This pattern is consistent with CW&C's own position (Section 5): an area can combine a comparatively low overall poverty rate with comparatively poor school readiness among its most disadvantaged children, and vice versa. It implies that factors other than the area-wide child poverty rate, for example, the intensity of local deprivation among FSM families specifically, the availability and quality of early years and family support services, or School / Reception-level factors are likely to matter more for FSM school readiness outcomes than the general child poverty rate alone. This is an observational, exploratory finding and should not be read as evidence that reducing child poverty would not improve school readiness; it indicates only that, at local authority level in a single year, the two headline rates do not move together strongly or consistently.

Limitations and Data Caveats

- Ecological (area-level) analysis: results describe area averages, not individuals, and are subject to the ecological fallacy patterns seen across areas do not necessarily hold for individual children or families.
- Small-cohort volatility: a small number of areas (notably City of London and Isles of Scilly) have very small underlying pupil denominators (as low as 5 pupils), which produces extreme and statistically unstable percentage values (e.g. 100% or 0%). These points are shown in the charts but should be treated with caution and are excluded from the fitted trend line in Figure 3.
- Indicator scope: the school readiness figures used in Questions 2 and 3 (B02a) relate specifically to children with free-school-meal status, not to all children in Reception. This is a subgroup measure of disadvantaged children's outcomes, not an overall school readiness rate, and this distinction matters for interpretation.
- Source workbook labelling: in the original workbook's Question 3 pivot table, the column headers 'B01b' and 'B02a' were transposed relative to the values beneath them. This report's figures and statistics use the values verified directly against the indicator-level source sheets (matching, e.g., the published England figures of 19.8% for B01b and 51.3% for B02a in 2024/25) and are labelled correctly throughout.
- Provisional data: 2024/25 figures may be provisional and subject to revision by DfE/OHID in future publication cycles.

- No causal inference: this is a cross-sectional, exploratory analysis. It does not control for other determinants (e.g. ethnicity, English as an additional language, SEND, local service provision) and cannot establish causality in either direction.